inspectors should verify the absence of missiles, not monitor the process of their removal, demurred.

On the same day Kuznetsov wrote to Moscow, asking his government to speed up the dismantling of the missile sites. “If the dismantling is carried out in a short time, then the issue of inspection during the dismantling process will not arise at all,” he cabled his boss in Moscow, Andrei Gromyko. But Kuznetsov was also in favor of accommodating U Thant’s request by showing him already dismantled launchers. “We propose,” wrote Kuznetsov, “that it would be appropriate to show U Thant himself the dismantling of certain installations during his stay in Cuba on 30 and 31 October. In such an event he would take a firmer stance, and it would be more difficult for the Americans to renew their ‘quarantine’ of Cuba. If this is recognized as expedient, I request urgently to give corresponding instructions to Havana.”[22]

Khrushchev found Kuznetsov’s suggestions attractive, and on October 31, with U Thant already in Cuba, Gromyko issued urgent instructions to the Soviet ambassador in Havana, Alekseev. “In Moscow,” wrote Gromyko, “we consider it necessary to satisfy U Thant’s desire that the launchers, which are being dismantled, be shown to him and persons accompanying him.” Alekseev’s other task was to inform Pliev about the decision to show the launchers to U Thant and his people. “We proceed from the assumption that the Cuban government and Comrade Pavlov [Pliev] would undertake all necessary measures on site,” read the cable.[23]

The task entrusted to Alekseev turned out to be impossible to fulfill, since Castro and his government refused to allow U Thant to visit the missile sites. Alekseev therefore decided to accommodate the request of General Indar Jit Rikhye, who served as a military adviser to U Thant and accompanied him on the trip, to meet with the Soviet commander in Cuba. General Issa Pliev apparently refused to meet with Rikhye and volunteered instead General Igor Statsenko, the commander of the missile division on the island.

The meeting took place at U Thant’s temporary residence in the presence of Alekseev. Statsenko later recalled that U Thant was the only participant who asked questions, while General Rikhye remained silent, making notes. For Statsenko, the last-minute request to meet with U Thant